

Build a clear prompt → Explore → Iterative vs single → Refine → PDF template → Verify output

Build a clear prompt

Activity · Prompting techniques · ~15 min

BEFORE YOU START

- ☐ You're signed in to the FASTR platform with the AI Assistant available
- ☐ You have a real workshop task in mind that you'd normally do (a chart, a summary, a slide for a meeting)

WHY IT MATTERS

A clear prompt produces a useful answer; a vague prompt produces a generic one. The difference is **what you put in** — most of the value comes from a 30-second pre-flight before you type.

Six dimensions before you type

Pick a task you do regularly. Before writing your prompt, check it covers these six dimensions.

- 1. Clear objective.** Is the task explicit (*interpret, summarize, compare, draft slides*) and the use case named (*performance review, donor update, training*)?
- 2. Target audience.** Who's it for? At what technical level?
- 3. Geography, period, scope.** National or subnational? Time period? Priority indicators or services?
- 4. Interpretation guidance.** Should the AI describe, compare, or identify disruptions? Description only, or include implications?
- 5. Output format.** Bullets or narrative? Slide-ready or prose? Length limit?
- 6. Guardrails.** Tell the AI to stick to the data shown and flag uncertainties or data-quality issues.

Now write your prompt

Use the six dimensions above to write a prompt that names **objective**, **audience**, **scope**, **interpretation guidance**, **format**, and **guardrails**. One paragraph is fine.

Your prompt:

The golden rule

Before you press Enter, ask yourself: *"Is what I expect back obvious?"* If not, add one more detail.

Refining is normal too. You don't have to get the prompt right in one go — you can keep talking to the AI to narrow it down. The six dimensions above just give you a stronger first message.

What's next

Move on to **Explore with the AI Assistant** to try this prompt against the platform and learn how small changes to a prompt change the output.